

Non-factualism

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1. The view

Nonfactualists about some class of declarative sentences in a certain language say that although sentences in that class are meaningful, they do not express propositions.

- It's already clear that there are meaningful bits of language that don't express propositions—subsential expressions; questions; imperatives (arguably).
- Some important candidates for this status: moral sentences (those of the form 'X is right/wrong/good/bad'...); aesthetic sentences; 'funny', 'tasty'; epistemological sentences ('this is good evidence for that/reason to believe that'); epistemic modals ('might P', 'must P', 'probably P', 'it's likely that P'); conditionals.

A not-so-great follow-up question: 'What do they express, then, if not propositions?'

Before plunging into that sort of question, we want to consider what it *is* for a sentence (as used by a certain linguistic community) to express a certain proposition.

- Once we have a sense for how we might answer that question we might be in a position to describe some *other* relation between a sentence and a linguistic community that does *not* suffice for the sentence to express any proposition for that community, but is still similar in some ways to the relations that do so suffice so that we can see why it's should count as a way of being meaningful.
- Whether we want to characterise this other relation as a matter of "expressing" something other than a proposition is neither here nor there—"express" here is a term of art.

2. Crash course in intention-based metasemantics

There are many many kinds of answers to the question 'What is it for a sentence to express a proposition for a community?' that suggest all kinds of different generalisations. I'm going to just look at one small family, influenced by David Lewis (*Convention*, 'Languages and Language') and Bennett (*Linguistic Behavior*).

- One of its hallmarks is that it analyses this notion in *mental* terms—expressing P in a community is a matter of the knowledge, beliefs, desires, intentions, ... of people in the community.
- A regularity is a *convention* in a community iff (roughly) people in the community generally abide by it; expect each other to abide by it; prefer abiding by it themselves assuming others do; and know all of the above.

First approximation: S expresses P in C iff there is a convention in C that one doesn't utter S unless one believes P.

- Alternative completions:
 - one knows P
 - one intends one's audience to believe that P on the basis of one's saying it
 - one intends one's audience to believe that one believes P
 - P is true
 - one intends that everyone in the conversation should believe P, believe that everyone else believes P; believe that everyone else believes that; etc.

3. Generalisations

Each of these views suggests certain generalisations—binary relations between sentences and communities similar in structure to the relations of expressing P, but different.

EG: Suppose we think that the central convention concerning 'Snow is white' is that one does not utter it unless one intends one's audience to believe that snow is white. One could then think, similarly, that one not utter 'Lying is wrong' unless one intends one's audience to disapprove of lying.

- By contrast, the convention for 'I disapprove of lying' will be that one not utter it unless one intends one's audience to believe that one disapproves of lying. This is totally different!

4. Expressivism

Expressivists about sentences in a certain class hold that the functioning of sentences in that class in the relevant community can be summed up by associating each such sentence S with a certain mental state M(S) which is not the state of believing some proposition.

The idea is that *whatever* the important relation is an ordinary factual sentence expressing P in a community bears to the mental state of *believing P*, that same relation holds between S and M(S).

- An attempt to avoid having to commit to any particular metasemantics.
 - E.g. maybe M('lying is wrong') = disapproval of lying
 - E.g. maybe M('it is probably raining') = having credence at least 0.5 that it is raining
 - E.g. maybe M('if it is raining the ground is wet') = having high conditional credence that the ground is wet given that it is raining.

- note that this would be particularly natural

5. Truth and falsity for sentences

If being a true/false sentence is just expressing a true/false proposition, then clearly nonfactualists about a certain class of sentences must think that sentences in that class are never true or false.

- Bennett, Adams don't want to do this — they want to say that 'If P, Q' is false when P is true and Q is false.
- My view: 'true sentence' is pretty much a term of art—in natural language 'true' is normally used in constructions like 'She said something true'. So it doesn't matter much what we say.

6. The "Frege-Geach problem" (or challenge)

The challenge: it's not enough to just talk about some family of simple sentences involving X-type vocabulary. We need a theory that gives us a systematic way of characterising the meanings of *all* well-formed sentences involving X-type vocabulary.

- This includes, e.g., negations and disjunctions, including 'mixed' ones. 'Lying is not wrong'; 'Either lying is wrong or gambling is wrong'; 'Either lying is wrong or snow is white'; 'Lying is wrong and gambling is wrong'.
- Also sentences with quantifiers and modals
- And mental state ascriptions. 'She believes that lying is wrong'; 'She is pretty confident that lying is wrong'; 'She hopes that lying is wrong'; 'She is pretty confident that either lying is wrong or gambling is wrong'...

Much of the history of discussion on this point consists in people saying very programmatic things — 'reasons for optimism' rather than theories.

- In the case of conditionals, there has considerable emphasis on the fact that *some* embeddings of conditionals are hard to interpret. OK, but many others are not and we need a theory for them